Source: Election Commission of India (ECI) data. Analysis by Nalin Mehta, Rishabh Srivastava, PollNiti.

These deep-seated vote-share shifts in favour of the BJP also reflected in seats won. In the Hindi heartland, the BJP won less than one-third of the rural seats in 2009, but as much as 77.9 per cent in 2014 and 70.8 per cent in 2019. Similarly, in UP, the party went from winning just 8.6 per cent of rural seats in 2009 to 82.6 per cent in 2014 and 76 per cent in 2019. Figure 2.3 spatially maps how the BJP's advances in rural areas changed the political map of UP and the Hindi heartland in the space of a decade. Yet, the overall seat-share changes tell an incomplete story. They are often built on a lower voting base that could be overturned anytime. Mapping how deeper vote shares change is more meaningful as a way of tracking structural change. Our analysis found that, in 2019, the BJP not only retained most of its numbers in the Hindi heartland overall, and UP in particular, it actually made significant advances in rurban and rural areas.

FIGURE 2.2: The BJP Significantly Expanded Its Rural Base in UP, While Key Rivals Shrank (2009–2019)

